Read Words in Context

READ!

Marco Polo—Man of a Million Wonders

You don't have to **persuade** true explorers to set sail, soar into space, or plunge into the ocean's depths. You don't have to give them reasons to **convince** them that travel is rewarding. For them, the act of seeking adventure is the reward. They are eager to agree to, or **assent** to, any trip that brings new experiences. It may be an **ascent** to the top of a towering mountain or a descent to the depths of the ocean. It may mean pitching a **canvas** tent in the desert for five months to observe the surroundings or spending four hours underwater in a metal cage to observe sharks.

One of the most famous travelers of all times is Marco Polo. If you **canvass** people, you will find that most know his name.

In the latter part of the thirteenth century, Marco Polo traveled throughout Asia with his uncles, two Venetian merchants, for almost 24 years. They lived at the court of Kublai Khan, the emperor of China. Marco Polo became a favorite of the Khan. Intelligent and eager to learn, he could speak four languages without an **accent**, and so the Khan sent him on missions to the far corners of his kingdom.

When Polo returned home to Venice, he told many amazing stories of the marvelous things he saw. Some stories seemed so **bizarre** or strange that no one would believe him. From the royal court to the local street **bazaar**, or stalls where merchants sold their wares, he earned the nickname "Il Milion," because almost every story seemed to include an extraordinary number of something wonderful. For example, one told of a magnificent palace with a dining hall for 6,000 people. Another told of 10,000 white horses owned by the Khan.

Even today, Marco Polo is a popular figure. Restaurants are named after him and he is sometimes shown in **cartoons** in the Sunday paper.

If you find a **carton** or box of old books at a bazaar, see if it contains a copy of *The Travels of Marco Polo*. Read it and a world of adventure will open up to you.

Vocabulary Words

accent/ascent/assent
bazaar/bizarre
canvas/canvass
carton/cartoon
convince/persuade

Word Learning Tip!

English contains some words that are easily confused. These words may sound alike, or they may be spelled very much alike but sound a bit different. However, they have very different meanings. In some cases, the confusing words came from different languages.

Vocabulary Building Strategy

When you read an easily confused word, make sure that you are pronouncing the word correctly. A difference of just one letter can make the word entirely different! Pay close attention to the letters in each word and create a clue to remember the meaning and spelling of each word.

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Connect Words and Meanings

accent/ascent/assent	**canvas/canvass**	**convince/persuade**
bazaar/bizarre	**carton/cartoon**	

Directions Match each vocabulary word in the left-hand column with its definition and history in the right-hand column. Write the letter of the definition in the blank by the word.

____	**1.** carton	**A.** a strong, coarse cloth; from a Latin word for *hemp*, a plant used to make rope
____	**2.** convince	**B.** strange, odd, fantastic; from the Italian word *bizzarro*, meaning "angry, fierce, or strange"
____	**3.** accent	**C.** a box or container usually made of cardboard or plastic; from the Italian word *cartone*, meaning "pasteboard" because boxes were made of pasteboard
____	**4.** bizarre	**D.** the way that you pronounce things; to stress or emphasize; from a Latin word that means "song"
____	**5.** canvass	**E.** a market, especially one held outdoors; from the Persian word *bāzār*, meaning "market"
____	**6.** persuade	**F.** to make someone see the truth or believe what you have to say; from the Latin word *convincere*, meaning "to prove, to overcome"
____	**7.** cartoon	**G.** an upward slope or rise; moving or rising up; from the Latin word meaning "to climb up"
____	**8.** ascent	**H.** a drawing or animated comic strip; from the Italian word *cartone*, meaning "pasteboard" because it was originally drawn on pasteboard
____	**9.** bazaar	**I.** to gather support; to ask people for their opinions and votes; to examine carefully; from a word that is no longer used that meant "to toss a person into a canvas sheet" and then came to mean "to toss out"
____	**10.** canvas	**J.** to agree to something; from the Latin word *assentire*, meaning "to feel"
____	**11.** assent	**K.** to succeed in making someone do something; from the Latin word *persuadere*, meaning "to urge"

Understand *Persuade* vs. *Convince* When you *persuade* someone, your goal is to try to get them to do something. When you *convince* them, in contrast, you try to get them to believe that something is true. *Persuade* is often followed by the word *to*; *convince* is followed by the word *that*. Write sentences using each word. Make sure that your sentences show that you understand the difference between these easily confused words.

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Use Words in Context

accent/ascent/assent	**canvas/canvass**	**convince/persuade**
bazaar/bizarre	**carton/cartoon**	

Directions Below is a list of equipment that an explorer might need. Choose the correct vocabulary word to complete each item. Write it on the line.

1. Be sure to bring along a _____ (*carton, cartoon*) to carry your supplies.
2. You also need some _____ (*canvas, canvass*) fabric to use for your sails.
3. Don't forget hiking boots to use on your _____ (*accent, ascent, assent*) up the mountain.
4. Bring along some language tapes so that you can learn to speak a foreign language with the proper _____ (*accent, ascent, assent*).
5. No one has to urge or _____ (*convince, persuade*) you to bring a heavy parka to the Arctic.
6. We don't need to _____ (*convince, persuade*) you or prove that you need a space suit in outer space.
7. At a _____ (*bazaar, bizarre*), you can buy the food that you will need.
8. I'm sure that you will agree with, or _____ (*accent, ascent, assent*) to this proposal for the trip.
9. Remember that very high altitudes can cause people to act strangely and behave in a _____ (*bazaar, bizarre*) manner.
10. If you like to make a point through humorous drawings, bring paper and pencils to make a _____ (*carton, cartoon*) of your adventures.

Write a Journal Entry Imagine that you are the first person to explore your home town. Choose the year of your discovery and write a journal entry describing what you see. Talk about the land, especially the natural resources and landforms. You can also describe the weather, animals, and plants. Use all of the vocabulary words.

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Put Words Into Action

accent/ascent/assent	**canvas/canvass**	**convince/persuade**
bazaar/bizarre	**carton/cartoon**	

Directions Read each item below. Choose the correct word to fit in each blank. Write it on the line.

1. On July 16, 1969, Mike Collins, Neil A. Armstrong, and Edwin E. Aldrin, Jr., began their _____ (*accent, ascent, assent*) into space.

2. They were the first human beings to _____ (*canvas, canvass*) the surface of the moon by exploring the rocks and soil.

3. Do you think that they stored the soil samples they brought back in a special _____ (*carton, cartoon*) or box?

4. On their journey to the North Pole, Matthew Henson and Robert Peary carried their food and tools on sleds covered in tough _____ (*canvas, canvass*) cloth.

5. They learned to speak the Inuit language, too, but they probably spoke with an American _____ (*accent, ascent, assent*)!

6. Henson and Peary saw many things they expected, but some things that seemed _____, such as fierce storms that flung boulders around like rubber balls.

7. Travel books may fill people with curiosity and _____ (*convince, persuade*) them to explore faraway places.

8. You may be able to find old books about travel in a booth at a _____ (*bazaar, bizarre*).

9. The brochure tried to _____ (*convince, persuade*) the public that exploration of outer space was a vital concern for the country.

10. It contains a political _____ (*carton, cartoon*) that pokes fun at people who oppose this idea.

Create a Mnemonic Device Choose one of these sets of commonly confused words. Create a memory trick to help you remember it. For example: A *toon* is a character in a *cartoon*. A *ton* of bricks is too large for a *carton*.

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Review and Extend

accent/ascent/assent	**canvas/canvass**	**convince/persuade**
bazaar/bizarre	**carton/cartoon**	

Bonus Words Below is another pair of words that are often confused.

Words	History	Meaning
borrow	from the Old English *borgian*	to use something that belongs to someone else, with permission
lend	from the Middle English *lenen*	to let somebody have something temporarily

Directions Read each item below. Pay particular attention to the word in boldface. Use your understanding of that word to complete the sentence.

1. If you **lend** a book to someone, you expect _____
2. A **bizarre** creature you read about in a story might be _____
3. You might need a **carton** to carry _____
4. You might **canvass** the neighborhood to find out _____
5. If you particularly liked a movie, you might **persuade** a friend to _____
6. At a **bazaar** you might buy _____
7. You might give your **assent** to a friend's plan if _____
8. You might **borrow** someone's umbrella when _____

Write About Two Words That Confuse You Select two words that confuse you, such as *except* and *accept*. Then write a paragraph describing the clue you will use to remember these words.

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Check Your Mastery

Directions Circle the letter of the correct answer to each question below.

1. What would you most likely do with a **carton**?
A. pack things in it
B. drive it
C. watch it
D. carry it from place to place

2. Why would someone most likely go to a **bazaar**?
A. to learn a foreign language
B. to take a vacation
C. to visit friends
D. to buy things

3. Which of the following would be a **bizarre** event?
A. a leaf dropping from a tree
B. a kitten purring
C. a squirrel eating a nut
D. a monkey boarding a city bus

4. A **canvas** bag would be made of what?
A. fabric **B.** metal **C.** wood **D.** plastic

5. If you went to **canvass** the neighborhood, what would you want?
A. excuses **B.** company **C.** support **D.** fabric

Directions Choose the correct word to fit in each blank below. Write it on the line.

6. We wrapped the dishes in newspapers and packed them in a _____ (*carton, cartoon*).

7. Nothing you can say will _____ (*convince, persuade*) me to take up parachuting.

8. The climbers picked up their supplies and then began their _____ (*accent, ascent, assent*) of the mountain.

9. I am working to improve my _____ (*accent, ascent, assent*) when I speak Spanish.

10. Anita will _____ (*convince, persuade*) Christopher that she was right.

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